

It was a crime to not have a convertible when it was sunny so often. He then focused on deciding which features to add. To begin with, he needed air conditioning. With the constant heat, it was simply not an option he could live without. Of course, he felt he also needed a leather interior and top of the line rims for his tires. A good sound system was a necessity, so he made sure they installed a top of the line CD player. Without these features, it would be embarrassing to drive around with the women whom he was dating.

As features were added or upgraded, the sticker price that Jack had initially seen was slowly being increased. Of course, the increase in price was not so apparent since the only figure Jack paid attention to was the monthly payment. He didn't realize that his loan had been stretched out to seven years or that his first year's payments were only covering the interest on his loan. None of this was important to Jack; only the fact that he knew he could afford the monthly payment.

As Jack drove away from his parents' house, leaving them in the driveway with worried looks on their faces, he told himself that they were just cheap. They were still driving a car that was built before he was born. He could afford his new car and that was all that mattered. Unfortunately, Jack soon came to realize that he only thought he could afford the convertible—reality said otherwise.

True, he could afford the car payment, but he didn't calculate the other expenses that went into car ownership. In addition to the car payment, there are four other major expenses involved in owning an automobile: gas, insurance, maintenance, and annual registration or car tax. Other minor expenses include traffic tickets, parking, tolls, and storage. Since Jack didn't plan for these expenses in advance, whenever he needed maintenance or repair work or had to buy gas, he ended up charging them on his credit card.

